

Appendix F

Recruiting Follow-Up Email

State of Practice of {domain} Software

E-mail Subject line: McMaster Study – State of Practice of {domain} Software Follow-Up Email

Hi {software package contact},

I apologize for contacting you a third time after promising that I would stop at two attempts. However, we have added a new way to participate in the study that may interest you. For those who do not have time for an interview, we have added the option of an online survey. As a reminder, I am a graduate student with a research group at McMaster University in Hamilton, Canada. This is my third, and last, email, regarding an invitation to participate in a research study that I am ([For Ziyang] completing as a requirement of my Master of Engineering degree [For Chris] assisting with).

Deleted: I am following up on an email that I had sent to you two weeks ago ...

I located your name/email by visiting the website of {research software name}.

The purpose of this study is to conduct a current state of practice analysis of software in a scientific computing domain for the purpose of understanding quality and assisting in the future development of such software. One of the domains is {software domain}.

We have selected {software package name} to be part of a list of (30) {software domain} packages that we have identified for analysis. These packages were selected because they are open source and fit our desired scope, usage, and age criteria.

Participation in this study will involve either an online survey, or a one-to-one semi-structured interview between a member of our research group and a lead developer of {software package name}. The choice of survey or interview is up to the participant. If an interview is select, the interview will be conducted using Microsoft Teams. The purpose of the survey and interview is to gather qualitative data regarding the development of {software package name}. The video-conference interview would include roughly 20 questions that focus on the software development process and the development group. The interview should not take longer than 60 minutes. The survey is based on the same questions and can typically be completed in about half the time as the interview.

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I have attached a copy of the letter of information with full details about the procedure of the research and potential benefits and risks. With respect to risks, the letter highlights that you may feel uncomfortable or anxious if you perceive that your project is being scrutinized. We also identify the risk of maintaining the privacy of interviewed sole developers, or members from a small developer team, since their identities can be inferred. The interviewee will have to accept this risk if they choose to be interviewed. If you choose to participate in the study, please let me know by responding to this email and stating that you want to participate in the study. Also, if you have any questions that you wanted answered before deciding to participate, please let us know.

Your personal confidentiality would be maintained and all qualitative data that we gather will be aggregated among all participants prior to the release of our findings.

If you choose to participate in the study, please know that you can rescind your consent at any time prior to the analysis of our findings.

If you wish to participate in the survey, you do not need to reply to this email. You can go directly to the survey here:

State of the Practice for Research Software Survey – Fill out form

If you prefer the interview option, you will need to reply to this email so that we can arrange an interview time.

Please let me know if I should be sending this request to a different person or email account associated with {software package name}.

Please let me know if you have any questions, I look forward to hearing from you.

I will not be sending any further follow-up emails.

This study has been reviewed by the McMaster Research Ethics Board and received ethics clearance under project 8215. If you have concerns or questions about your rights as a participant or about the way the study is conducted, please contact McMaster Research Ethics Office by phone: (905) 525-9140 ext. 23142 or e-mail: mreb@mcmaster.ca.

By replying to this email and agreeing to participate, you are affirming the following:

- I have read the information presented in the information letter about a study being conducted by Spencer Smith, Christopher Schankula and Ziyang Fang of McMaster University.
- I have had the opportunity to ask questions about my involvement in this study and to receive additional details I request.
- I understand that if I agree to participate in this study, I may withdraw from the study at any time or up until Aug 8th, 2026.
- I have a copy of this e-mail and the letter of information.
- I agree to participate in the study.

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Thank you,

{Student Investigator Name}
Masters Candidate in Computing and Software
Computing and Software Department
Computing and Software Department
McMaster University, Hamilton Ontario
[{Student Investigator Email}](#)

Spencer Smith
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Email Recruitment Script Follow-Up